

SACRED STONES

The Bible is full of references to precious gems – sapphires, diamonds, rubies, and pearls in particular. In both the Old and New Testaments, jewels are used as a metaphor to express how beautiful heaven will be. As a consequence, early medieval churches often used gems in their regalia, to decorate altars, and on the special vessels and vestments used in church services and processions. Some of the larger European monasteries had their own goldsmiths, and secular goldsmiths were also commissioned to make sacred, jewel-studded treasures.

Jewels also played a role in the Christian tradition of holy relics – the remains of a holy person, or objects they had touched – which were considered to be a bridge between heaven and earth and were the church's most valuable possessions. Skeletons believed to be saintly relics were draped in jewellery of gold, silver, and precious stones, while smaller relics were housed in ornate reliquaries (see pp.144–45). These containers made from precious metals and gems were often donated by pious worshippers and pilgrims. Such artefacts were intended to be physical manifestations of the spiritual treasures of the afterlife.

**I will make your
battlements of
rubies, your gates of
carbuncles... all your
walls of precious stones**

The **Bible**, Isaiah 54:11-12

The Adoration of the Mystic Lamb by Hubert and Jan van Eyck
Painted in 1432 by the van Eyck brothers for the altar of St Bavo Cathedral, Ghent, in the Netherlands, this oil painting shows luminous jewels set into the regalia of popes, bishops, and deacons.

